

Q. What is the significance of the community in this project?

A. The community is at the heart of our office software. The community consists of three key parts — the users who utilise our software, volunteers, and the ecosystem of companies who earn revenue from LibreOffice through added value services. The large number of users forms the foundation of our community. Without the vast user base, the software would have no relevance. The volunteers contribute in their free time, some receiving support from their companies to assist with LibreOffice. A few staff members from TDF are also part of this volunteering community. Companies in the ecosystem contribute back to the project through code development, or new features. If their code gets committed to LibreOffice, it's integrated into the core software and becomes open source, albeit customer-funded.

Q. What role do open source organisations like TDF play in the entire ecosystem?

A. There are many instances of companies and projects starting in the open source domain and then transitioning to a closed source model. A prominent example is ChatGPT from OpenAI, which was acquired by Microsoft and has since become closed source. This risk is mitigated by the Foundation, as the Foundation itself cannot be purchased by another company. The statutes of the Foundation dictate that everything it delivers and supports must benefit the users. TDF is committed to ensuring that the software remains open source indefinitely, upholding the principles of equality and accessibility. While this doesn't necessarily mean the software is always free, it should be low-cost for users. These rules and principles within the Foundation's statutes are designed to safeguard against the risks observed in other organisations and projects.

This commitment to maintaining open source integrity and user accessibility is a fundamental rule.

Q. Is it a good business model to start with open source and later make it closed source?

A. Transitioning from an open source model to closed source doesn't work well. We have seen instances, such as with Oracle and Apache regarding OpenOffice, where such attempts were made. The essence of open source lies in the freedom to work with the code and, if necessary, take that code and start independent activities with it. In the case of ChatGPT, if I disagree with the move to closed source, I have the right to take the existing open source code version and pursue my own open source projects. This is exactly what happened with LibreOffice. When faced with the prospect of Open Office taking a different direction, the community took the source code and said, "We will now organise our own open source project under our own brand." The risk for those who shift from open source to closed source is that another part of the community may take the existing open source code and continue its development independently, creating a competitive situation. This dynamic is what makes the open source model particularly resilient and, in my view, a sound business approach for ecosystem partners.

Q. What kind of challenges do businesses that transition from an open source model to a closed source model face?

A. All business around open source is, and always will be, fundamentally influenced by the fact that the source code is freely available. Anyone can take this open source code and use it in their projects, adhering to the specific licence terms. Transforming open source into closed source for the purpose of charging licensing fees or usage fees isn't a practical approach. The software

is already freely available in the open source domain, making such a business model ineffective. This is exemplified by the case of Star Office and Sun Microsystems, which transitioned from closed source to open source. Once this transition occurred, it was clear that no one would be successful in charging fees for the pure Star Office licence, for instance. This serves as a prime example of why simply taking code, making it closed source, and then charging for it isn't the best strategy. However, if the business model involves selling added value services around the software, then it makes sense and could potentially be a viable business case. It is about providing additional, valuable services or enhancements to the open source software, not just repackaging the freely available code and charging for it.

Q. How are companies able to maintain their competitive edge through open source?

A. To stay competitive, companies need to distinguish between collaborative and independent tasks. Development tasks, involving coding, often lead to companies seeking skilled developers from others, benefiting from their expertise. Conversely, someone may have different strengths, such as marketing. Collaboration enlarges the 'cake', offering a larger slice for everyone. Aspects such as marketing and branding are suited for individual handling, integral to a company's identity and strategy. While some tasks can be outsourced or collaboratively managed, critical areas, especially customer liability, demand company control. Liability guides in-house task determination, ensuring reliable and accountable delivery to customers. Internally managing responsibilities is vital for quality and trust. Balancing collaborative and independent work is crucial for a competitive edge, leveraging open source community strengths.